

ANI

▶ MANOHAR LAL KHATTAR, *70*

| BJP | ***Karnal, Haryana***

He is the one on whose motorcycle Narendra Modi used to ride pillion back in the day. Since 2014, the favour has been returned. Crafting a non-Jat caste coalition in Haryana and holding it up for nearly a decade was no mean achievement, but in the end, it also proved to be his Achilles heel. His own innovative farm policies became footnotes as agitating farmers took to the highways in protest. That may make the BJP's task in the upcoming assembly polls tougher. But Khattar's wattage hasn't waned. Instead, the former Haryana CM has been jack-plugged into the Union power ministry, with additional charge of urban development.



ANI

◀ JITAN RAM MANJHI, *79* | HAM (S) | *Gaya (SC), Bihar*

Once a clerk in the Posts and Telegraph department, Jitan Ram Manjhi couriered himself from party to party—Congress, Janata Dal, RJD, JD(U)—before floating his own in 2015. That was right after Nitish Kumar used him as a stopgap CM for nine months. But, as a Mahadalit, he carved his own viable niche. His Hindustani Awam Morcha (Secular)—it supports the BJP, never mind the brackets—proved the efficacy of small parties in Bihar's complex polity. The first Musahar to be CM is now the first Musahar to be a Union minister.

In 2013, the Left had won 50 out of Tripura's 60 seats—continuing its four-decade imperium. The BJP had 0 seats and 1.54 per cent of the votes. The man who turned that around in 2018, joining a historic turn in Northeast politics, is now in New Delhi. But his mind is still set on the throne back home. "A chief minister is the head of a state while a Union minister works under the prime minister. I prefer to return to state politics"—Biplab Deb was heard saying, just two days after he became an MP. Perhaps a Mahabharata awaits him, and this time certainly one that has the internet. But Parliament will be the stage for his verbal magniloquence for now.

BIPLAB KUMAR DEB, *52* ▶

| BJP | ***Tripura West***



-Anilesh S. Mahajan, Amitabh Srivastava, Dhaval S. Kulkarni and Ajay Sukumaran